



The Dispatcher's Daily Routine

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 17 of 18 · Closing & Mastery · about a 14-minute read

You've learned to run a single load flawlessly, start to finish. Now picture your actual desk on a Tuesday morning. You've got six trucks out. One needs its next load found. One's sitting at a shipper waiting to get loaded. One just texted that he's broken down. One delivers in ninety minutes. One has a rate confirmation sitting unsigned in your inbox. And one — you suddenly realize — you never checked on yesterday. Meanwhile the phone is ringing, two brokers are emailing, and it isn't even nine o'clock.

This is the job. And without a system, this is also exactly how balls get dropped: the forgotten check call becomes a late delivery, the unfound load leaves a truck empty tomorrow, the unsigned rate con holds up a pickup this afternoon.

The dispatchers who thrive on a full board aren't the ones who type fastest or panic hardest. They're the ones who run on a routine — a daily rhythm that makes sure every truck gets what it needs, when it needs it, and nothing slips. That's the difference between a board that runs you and a board you run.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Take a whole board of trucks through a day without dropping anything: you'll know the natural rhythm of a dispatcher's day, how to size up what's urgent versus what can wait, how to stay organized when six things need you at once, and how to end each day with every truck either rolling or set up for tomorrow. This is the lesson that turns all the individual skills into an actual job you can hold down.

1 From One Load to a Full Board

Everything up to now has been about one load at a time — and that was the right way to learn it, because you had to understand each step before you could run several at once. But the real job is a *board*: multiple trucks, each sitting at a different point in its own load's life. One's getting booked, one's at a dock, one's rolling, one's delivering, one's empty and waiting on you.

And here's the key insight: handling all of that isn't about doing each task faster. It's about having a *system* — a routine and a way to prioritize — so that every truck gets attention at the right moment and nothing is forgotten. Speed isn't what saves you on a busy board; **structure is**. So this whole lesson is about building that structure: a rhythm for the day, a way to triage, and a way to stay organized. Let's start with the rhythm.

2 The Daily Rhythm: Morning, Midday, End of Day

A dispatcher's day has a natural shape, and leaning into it keeps you ahead of the chaos instead of buried under it.

MORNING Your most important block — start strong

Before anything else, get the picture of your **whole board**: where is every truck, and what does each need *today*? Confirm today's pickups and deliveries, run your morning check calls, and deal with anything already on fire. By the time the morning's set, every truck that needs to move has a clear plan and you know your top priorities.

MIDDAY Keep-it-moving time

Monitor the loads in transit with check calls and tracking, handle problems as they pop up, and — just as important — *work ahead*: **booking the next loads** so trucks don't go empty, signing rate cons, setting appointments, answering brokers. The reactive and the proactive, side by side.

END OF DAY Close out and set up tomorrow

Confirm the day's deliveries are done and PODs are coming in, get invoices and paperwork out, and the most important habit: make sure **every truck is rolling or has a plan for tomorrow** — no truck sitting empty without a next load. Jot down what's still open so tomorrow starts informed.

3 Prioritize: Urgent vs Important

When six things want you at once, you triage — and the rule is to work by *impact*, not by who's loudest.

Urgent — comes first, every time

Anything time-critical right now: a truck broken down, a delivery appointment about to be missed, a driver stuck at a dock burning hours, a load that must be booked today or the truck sits empty tomorrow. **An empty or about-to-be-empty truck is lost money by the hour** — treat finding its next load like the emergency it is.

Important but not urgent — scheduled, not ignored

The proactive work: finding loads two days out, relationship calls with good brokers, paperwork that isn't due yet. It gets *scheduled* into the calmer parts of the day. The trap is letting the **loud** crowd out the **critical** — a chatty broker is not more important than the truck that needs a reload.

Handle what breaks a load or costs money first; then the rest. Triage like that and you're always spending your attention where it actually matters.

4 Stay Organized: See Every Truck, Track Every Task

You cannot hold six trucks in your head, and the dispatchers who try are the ones who drop things. So you externalize it.

First, you need a way to **see every truck's status at a glance** — each truck, where it is, what stage its load is in, what it needs next, and its next appointment. That might be a whiteboard, a spreadsheet, or, most commonly in a real operation, a **TMS — a Transportation Management System**, the dispatcher's software that holds the board, the dispatching, invoicing, and POD storage in one place. Whatever the tool, the point is the same: your whole board is visible, not living in your memory.

Second, you keep a **running task and follow-up list** — check calls due, rate cons to sign, loads to book, PODs to chase, invoices to send. Write it down; a busy day will absolutely make you forget the thing you "definitely won't forget." And third — the part people skip — you **keep it current**, updating status as things change, because a board that's out of date is worse than no board, since you'll trust it and be wrong. Visible board, written task list, kept current: that's the machinery that makes "nothing falls through" actually true.

5 Juggling Many Loads Without Dropping One

Put it together and a real day looks like constant switching: a check call, then a booking, then a problem, then a rate con, then back to the phone. It feels like chaos at first — but you now have everything that tames it. The **routine** gives you automatic coverage so nothing waits until it's a crisis. **Prioritizing by impact** keeps you on the things that matter, with the empty truck and the broken-down truck at the front. Your **board and task list** make sure no truck and no open item is invisible. And **communicating proactively** — updating brokers and drivers before they have to chase you — keeps the relationships smooth while you work.

Do that, and the chaos slowly turns into a rhythm you control. It becomes second nature, and here's the payoff: the better your routine, the *more* trucks you can run without dropping a thing. That right there — calm, organized, proactive, on top of a full board — is what mastery of this job actually looks like, day in and day out.

Walkthrough — A Dispatcher's Morning on a Full Board

Marcus and Unit 7 inside a small Summit board — the rest of the fleet on a Tuesday morning. 7:30 AM, pull up the board:

Summit Carriers — the board			7:30 AM · 5 trucks
UNIT	STATUS	WHERE IT STANDS	
Unit 7 Marcus	On track	Rolling Dallas→Atlanta on the reload — on schedule, heading home.	
Unit 2 Tom	Delivering	Delivering in Nashville at 9:00 AM.	
Unit 4 Dave	At dock	At a Memphis shipper, FCF5, waiting to load.	
Unit 9 Rosa	Broken down	Broke down overnight on I-40.	
Unit 12 Luis	Empty	Went empty in Oklahoma City yesterday — no next load yet.	

TRIAGE — BY IMPACT, NOT VOLUME

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|---------------|--|
| 1 • URGENT | Unit 9 breakdown → run the problem method: assess, call the broker with a plan, arrange repair, rework its delivery. |
| 2 • URGENT | Unit 12 empty → find a reload NOW before the day's good loads are gone (empty truck = lost money by the hour). |
| 3 • TIME-CRIT | Unit 2 delivers 9:00 → quick check call, confirm on time + POD plan. |
| 4 • LOW TOUCH | Unit 7 (Marcus) → morning check call, on track, move on. |
| 5 • MONITOR | Unit 4 at the dock → watch for detention; nothing urgent yet. |

MIDDAY → END OF DAY

MIDDAY

Monitor the rolling trucks; finalize Unit 12's reload + rate con; work Unit 9's repair updates + new delivery time; book tomorrow's loads.

End of day: Unit 2 delivered + POD in · Unit 4 loaded & rolling · Unit 9 repaired or planned · Unit 12 booked & moving · Unit 7 on track for Atlanta tomorrow. → **every truck rolling or planned.** Open items noted for tomorrow.

Five trucks, five different situations, one morning — and not one got dropped. That's not because the dispatcher was superhuman; it's because they *triaged by impact* (breakdown and empty truck first, the easy ones last), worked the *rhythm* (morning picture → midday execution → end-of-day close-out), and trusted a *board* instead of their memory. Marcus's smooth load got a thirty-second check call; the breakdown and the empty truck got the real attention. That's the whole craft of running a board.

Module 17 Glossary — your quick reference

The one tool that holds the whole board together.

Running the board

TMS (Transportation Management System) The dispatcher's software that holds the whole board in one place — each truck's status, the dispatching, invoicing, and POD storage — so the operation is visible instead of living in your memory. (A whiteboard or spreadsheet can serve the same purpose on a small board.)

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **Why does a dispatcher running several trucks need a routine and a system, rather than just working faster?**
2. **What are the three parts of a dispatcher's daily rhythm, and what happens in each?**
3. **Five things need you: a broken-down truck, a chatty broker call, a load for two days out, a delivery in 30 minutes, and a truck that just went empty. What order do you work them?**
4. **How do you keep track of many trucks at once?**
5. **What separates a dispatcher buried in chaos from one calmly on top of a full board?**

ANSWERS

1. Many trucks are at different stages at once; speed alone drops things. A routine, prioritization, and an organized board ensure every truck gets attention at the right time and nothing falls through.
2. Morning — get the whole-board picture, confirm today's pickups/deliveries, run check calls, set priorities. Midday — monitor loads, handle problems, book next loads, paperwork. End of day — confirm deliveries/PODs, make sure every truck is rolling or has a plan for tomorrow, close paperwork.
3. Urgent and impact first — the breakdown, the delivery in 30 minutes, and the empty truck (costing money now); then the two-days-out load (important, not urgent); the chatty broker last. Work by impact, not by who's loudest.
4. A system (whiteboard, spreadsheet, or a TMS) showing each truck's status, next need, and appointment, plus a running task/follow-up list — and you keep it current rather than relying on memory.
5. Not speed or talent — it's a routine (automatic coverage), prioritizing by impact, an organized and current board and task list, and proactive communication. The chaos becomes a controlled rhythm.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 18: HANDLING HARD CONVERSATIONS

You can now run the whole job — a full board of trucks, day after day, with the rhythm and the system to keep it all moving. There's one last skill, and it's the most human one of all. No routine, no software, no perfect plan ever removes the moment when you have to tell a broker something they don't want to hear, calm a driver who's coming apart on the phone, or hold your ground in a tense call without making it worse. How you handle those moments shapes your reputation as much as anything else you do. So for the final piece, we slow down and get good at the hard part: handling hard conversations.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches the daily routine as a generic skill. Your own operation adds its specifics — its daily routine and shift structure and any morning huddle; its actual board or TMS and how trucks and tasks are tracked in it; its priority rules and escalation (what jumps the line, and when to pull in a lead); how many trucks per dispatcher it runs, and coverage and handoff between shifts; and its end-of-day checklist — what must be closed before logging off. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*

